

Professional Skills I: Presenting Lecture Notes, Day 1

Main point of this session:

Concentration - ability to enter a state of embodiment without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind.

Relaxation - ability to use only the muscular energy needed at any given time, no more and no less.

Learning objectives for today:

- Why learn public speaking?
- How to overcome anxiety on stage?
- Concentration and relaxation

Activity (5 min explanation, + 10-15 mins game)

Ball game to learn names and train presence

Confession (3 min)

We are not professional actors. Sometimes, we don't know what we're talking about. However, we know how to give a good presentation! And we will give you good, on-point feedback. Let's go through this together.

We're all here because of technical skills, but what's really going to take you far is your presentation skills.

Why learn to present? Why be good at this? Do you want to... (6 minutes + 4 minutes)

ACE JOB INTERVIEWS	NOT BE NERVOUS	PITCH YOUR BUSINESS
GO INTO POLITICS	BE ON CAMERA	BE ON STAGE
CREATE CONTENT ONLINE	TEACH	DO PUBLIC SPEAKING
BE ENTERTAINING	BE PERSUASIVE	BE CONFIDENT
INITIATE A REVOLUTION	HOST YOUR OWN SHOW	IMPROVE ENGLISH

EXPRESS EMOTION	BE CHARISMATIC	<i>*YOUR REASON HERE*</i>
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Each of you has a reason why they want to become better at communicating. What is it? Please think about it and write it down in your notebooks.

I'll tell you my reason. <reason goes here>

Slow process (finish by 40 min mark)

Knowledge of how to best go about public speaking can be obtained relatively quickly. Embodied skills, on the other hand, take a long time to learn and internalize. Actors study the same things over and over for years, and it takes those years of practice to reach proficiency. We don't have years (only two weeks), but with the knowledge from this course you will be able to start your journey of public speaking, and continue improving continuously on your own. Start practicing outside of class today!

So we are going to start slowly. Nevertheless, by the end of this course you will have reached the level where you can write, design, and perform your own small TED talk.

How to overcome nervousness and anxiety when in front of people (5 mins)

It's inevitable that you will feel anxious when on stage. Often, people are anxious because they are afraid of failing publicly, or being judged. One can get used to the feeling of being the center of attention, and then be less nervous in that context. However, you should realize that as soon as the stakes are raised higher, the same person that didn't feel scared of presenting will now get anxious. For example, I can be calm and relaxed when teaching here at ULTA, because for me the stakes are low. But when I apply to grad school, I will need to pass interviews with multiple professors. The thought of having to present my work to MIT professors for them to judge me and decide whether I will be accepted into the graduate program can make me anxious.

— BREAK — (45 min mark)

The only way to stop shaking on stage (5 min)

Inevitably, there will be times when you will feel anxious before having to speak in front of people. Thoughts will be rushing through your head, your muscles will get tense, your hands will shake. Your voice will tremble. And of course, you are going to feel like it's going to ruin your presentation. You know you need to relax, somehow.

Simply telling yourself to "calm down" usually doesn't work. So what to do in this situation? Today, we will learn the two techniques that actually DO work.

[I] CONCENTRATION (3 min)

Concentration - ability to enter a state of embodiment without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind.

In other words, the ability to suppress conscious thinking.

[II] RELAXATION (3 min)

Relaxation - ability to use only the muscular energy needed at any given time, no more and no less.

In other words, the ability to relax any unnecessary tension in your body.

Breathing, Gazing, Grounding (3 min)

These are tools to help you enter the state of concentration and relaxation. Instead of thinking in language, concentrate on the feeling of your breath coming in and out of your lungs. Concentrate on the shapes and objects you see in front of you. Concentrate on the feeling of your body resting on the floor or in the chair. Let this concentration consume you fully, such that there is no space left for language-based thoughts.

Meditation session (10-15 min)

Lie down

Stretch and get comfortable

Close your eyes, or keep them open if you prefer

enter a state of embodiment without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind

feel your breath...

If a thought comes into your mind, recognize it and let it go...

Feel the ground beneath you supporting you...

If any of your muscles are tense, try to relax them: relax your face, ears, chin, neck, shoulder blades, spine, core, arms, legs, ankles, toes.

Now, if you've had your eyes closed, open them

Let your eyes softly gaze around the room, noticing shapes, color, and texture...

Now find a spot on the wall or ceiling, and let your eyes rest there...

Exercise (15 minutes)

Everybody gets up, one at a time, in front of us, practices concentration and relaxation for 10 seconds, and then speaks. Students say their name and tell their motivation to learn how to speak in public.

Preview for the next day: Meaningful gesture (10 minutes)

Meaningful gesture - specific use of physicality / gesture to support the clarity of your storytelling (as opposed to random, vague or meaningless gesture born from a lack of concentration / relaxation). Home bases - a form of meaningful gesture; "resting" postures for a character.

Homework "exit ticket"

Write down on a piece of paper a topic for a story that you want to practice with on Wed, Thur, Fri. Examples:

- Stray dog
- Fantasy novel
- Learning Spanish
- SQL injections
- AI

Your topic should be 2-5 words.